

you could feel a draught from one of the lethal bottomless pits scattered around, hear a pack of bats that would carry you away to a random cave, or even smell the mighty beast itself.

The object of the game was to fire an arrow into the room which contained the Wumpus.

This was the early age of personal computer hardware and the gaming: a few kilobytes of memory and a few megabytes of hard disk space were luxurious commodities, and it was assumed that the computer would be as interesting to users as HAM radio is to FM listeners. In fact, even Bill Gates went on to proclaim that “640 K ought to be enough for anybody,” and that “No one would need more than 637 KB of memory for a personal computer.”

Much has changed: After 25 years of evolution, the PC has now become the centre of all things technology. Complex mathematical calculations that required mainframes in the past can now be easily done on a laptop. Graphics hardware, which did not even merit a mention in the past, has now become *the* criterion for buying a gaming computer.

These changes did not happen overnight. Like in any other evolution, the PC took its time to get the attention that it has now. Let's take a non-specific look at some of the main architectural changes that have happened since the 1980s and that directly pertain to the gaming experience.

The Processor: From running at 108 kHz, Intel's processors have broken speed records and are currently at speeds upwards of 3.4 GHz. The same goes for the AMD tribe, who have gone a step ahead and come up with a 64-bit edition that provides a larger data address bus and also higher on-CPU memory cache sizes, leading to better overall system performance.

The Memory: RAM, which has always been the type of